

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: ARKANSAS TECH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: September 24-27, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Arkansas Tech University
LOCATION	Russellville, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Educator preparation program, literacy (elementary K-6)
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	September 24-27, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Meets
Concepts of print instruction	Approaching
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Meets
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Meets
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Meets
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Meets
Writing instruction	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that two courses, RDNG 3003 Teaching Literacy Foundations and RDNG 4003 Literacy Assessment and Intervention, trained candidates well in the science of reading and spiraled the literacy components across both. Candidates studied and compared the Simple View of Reading, Scarborough's Reading Rope, and the Four-Part Processing Model. Faculty labeled and modeled instruction, and candidates practiced through scenarios, peer teaching, videotaped lessons, and a library of high-quality instructional materials. Candidates learned to administer DIBELS, PAST, MAZE, the Core Phonics Survey, and DSA writing assessments and to plan instruction from the results. Reviewers rated concepts of print and writing instruction lower, finding that the courses needed greater focus on writing across the curriculum and on strategies for multilingual learners.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Select and implement • Model and rehearse • Use, collect, and analyze • Plan and teach	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Meets
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Meets
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Meets
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Meets
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Meets
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Meets
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Meets
Quality of written and oral feedback	Meets
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that the program placed most candidates in high-performing or improving schools with diverse student bodies, and that mentor teachers were selected against criteria the program and schools agreed on and were dropped from the rotation when they did not model effective practice. Candidates used high-quality instructional materials such as Foundations and Wit and Wisdom in placements, supported by a university materials library. Field experience taken alongside RDNG 4003, then Residency A and Residency B, gave candidates a structured gradual release into full responsibility. Written feedback had improved since the previous inspection, though oral feedback sometimes centered on classroom management. Opportunities to apply learning with multilingual children were inconsistent.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Expand on existing work • Train evaluators • Monitor • Provide support	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Meets
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Exceeds
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Meets
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that the program collected reliable data from state and cooperative surveys and from evaluator observation records, and used it to improve feedback quality, evaluator training, and the infusion of science of reading content through the literacy courses. Four internal checkpoints governed candidate progress, from prerequisite coursework and background checks through internship and licensure, with documented action plans for candidates who struggled. Improvement planning was the strongest element, supported by a tracked database of action plans with measurable goals reviewed with the teacher education council and district partners. Reviewers found monitoring of observation and feedback data insufficiently rigorous and partnership evaluation surveys not specific enough about literacy field experiences.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Review data • Develop targets • Create training • Monitor and evaluate	

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, Arkansas Tech University, September 24-27, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.